A Manhole Cover Comedy Wins Top Prize at Tokyo Film Festival

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Milcho Manchevski's "Sister Brother Manhole Cover" has won the top prize at the 39th Tokyo International Film Festival, closing a festival that opened on October 26.

Jury president Rolf de Heer said the **jury** chose the film "for the humanity and compassion shown towards its characters" and for being "a complex, coherent film that manages to be both touching and playful." The prize carries 3 million yen, about $19,000.

The film follows Viktor and Malina, siblings who make their living stealing manhole covers and copper busts. When a stolen bronze bust of a national hero lands on Viktor's foot, the pair tumble into the lowest depths of the North Macedonian capital. It is a **co-production** between North Macedonia, Bulgaria, Serbia, Albania, Italy and the U.K.

With Manchevski already gone from Tokyo, producer Jane Kortoshev and the film's leads, Sara Klimoska and Filip Trajkovi?, accepted the prize. "We came here to Tokyo with a manhole cover, and we are going back to Macedonia with a beautiful award," Kortoshev said. "I'd say it's a pretty good deal, huh?"

Manchevski appeared by video message. "This award is a little **vindication** for a **quirky** film that almost did not happen," he said. "A film about unusual families, and about the haves and have-nots. A film not about messages, but about people."

Other prizes went to films from around the world. The Special **Jury** Prize went to Sun Xun's "Magic Atlas" from Singapore, an animated feature the artist spent about a decade making. Lisandro Alonso won best director for "Double Freedom," Narita Ryo won best actor, Hu Ling won best actress, and Jelena Maksimovi?'s "Until the Day Ends" took best artistic contribution.

A steady **drizzle** failed to dampen the spirits of the full house at Hulic Hall for closing night.

Word Treasure

jury -- A small group of people chosen to judge a competition and pick the winners.

co-production -- A film made together by partners from several countries who share the costs and work.

vindication -- Proof that someone was right all along, after others doubted them.

quirky -- Unusual in a charming or funny way; a little bit odd.

drizzle -- Very light rain made of tiny drops.

Background you need

A film festival is a showcase and competition where new films are screened and a jury picks winners for prizes such as best film.

The Tokyo International Film Festival is one of Asia's major festivals, and its top prize goes to a single standout film.

Many European films are co-productions, made by partners in several countries pooling money and crews, as this winning film was.

Break it down

LEAD: A North Macedonian comedy about manhole-cover thieves wins Tokyo's top prize
KEY EVENT: Closing night of the 39th Tokyo International Film Festival
+- WHO: Director Milcho Manchevski; jury president Rolf de Heer
+- FILM: Siblings Viktor and Malina steal manhole covers and copper busts
REACTION: Producer Jane Kortoshev joked they came with a manhole cover and leave with a beautiful award
OPEN QUESTION: What the prize will mean for the film's release around the world

Why it matters

A small, quirky film from a small country beating bigger productions shows that festivals can reward heart and humor, not just big budgets.

Test what you remember

1. Which film won the top prize at the Tokyo festival?

- (A) 'Magic Atlas'
- (B) 'Double Freedom'
- (C) 'Sister Brother Manhole Cover'
- (D) 'Until the Day Ends'

2. What do Viktor and Malina steal to make a living?

- (A) Paintings
- (B) Movie cameras
- (C) Manhole covers and copper busts
- (D) Cars

3. How much is the top prize worth?

- (A) Only a gold statue
- (B) 100,000 yen
- (C) $1 million
- (D) 3 million yen, about $19,000

4. Why did the jury choose the film, according to Rolf de Heer?

- (A) Because it was made in Japan
- (B) Because it was the longest film
- (C) For its humanity and compassion, and for being touching and playful
- (D) For its special effects

5. Who accepted the prize in Tokyo?

- (A) The mayor of Tokyo
- (B) The jury president
- (C) Producer Jane Kortoshev and the film's leads
- (D) The director himself

6. Which film won the Special Jury Prize?

- (A) 'Sister Brother Manhole Cover'
- (B) 'Magic Atlas' from Singapore
- (C) 'Double Freedom'
- (D) A film by Narita Ryo

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: D 4: C 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Jury president Rolf de Heer: Praised the film's humanity and compassion toward its characters, and called it touching and playful.

2. Director Milcho Manchevski: Called the award a little vindication for a quirky film that almost did not happen, and said it is about people, not messages.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):